

Baroque in France

During the 17th century, France began to challenge Italy for dominance in the visual arts. French Baroque art was more classical and sedate, and less overtly Catholic than the corresponding art in Italy. In 1627, Louis XIII summoned the French painter Simon Vouet (1590–1649) to his court from Italy where he had spent 14 successful years. Vouet brought with him the Baroque style, adapting it to suit Louis's lavish tastes. His pupil, Charles le Brun (1619–90), became the favourite artist of Louis XIV and director of the newly opened Académie Royale de Peinture et de Sculpture in 1648. His pupil, Hyacinthe Rigaud (1659–1743), became the quintessential Baroque portrait painter.

Well known for dignified paintings of peasant life were brothers Antoine (c.1588–1648), Louis (c.1600–48) and Mathieu (1607–77) Le Nain, who established a Paris workshop in 1630. Yet while Paris was the most important French art centre, it was not the only one: working in Lorraine, Georges de la Tour (1593–1652) became known for contemplative images, inspired by Caravaggio.



Vouet, *Saint Catherine of Alexandria*, date unknown